

The world was quite a different place when folk-fusion act Indian Ocean last released an album, 2014's star-studded collaborative experiment *Tandanu*. Narendra Modi had swept to power. Vladimir Putin had annexed Crimea in Russia's smaller first invasion of Ukraine. Barack Obama was still in the White House. The climate crisis still seemed solvable, rather than inevitable. We live in darker, more dangerous times now.

But this is still a world in which Indian Ocean's central thesis—love for the environment, syncretic philosophy, and for each other—is relevant, and the band stays on-message for their eighth album *Tu Hai*, released on May 5. The six tracks on the album all deal with themes of sustainable living and spiritual renewal, set to music that blends Indian classical and folk traditions with elements of progressive rock, spiritual jazz and agit-pop.

"We'd accumulated these songs and were finally ready to present them to the world when Covid hit," says the band's guitarist Nikhil Rao, speaking over Zoom, along with vocalist Himanshu Joshi. "Once we put them together, we realised that they all dealt with concerns that are all around us and that we ourselves struggle with. Like environmental stuff, rampant materialism, or debates about God. Questions that everyone has struggled with at some point in their lives," says Rao.

The lead single 'Jaadu Maya'—a collaboration with writer-comedian-film-maker Varun Grover originally written for the *Masaan* (2015) soundtrack—is a haunting dirge for a world at war with itself, and a call to arms to save it despite its imperfections. Joshi credits Grover for the song's compelling visual imagery. "For me, Varun is on the same pedestal as Gulzaar Saab," he says. "He can say in two lines what would normally take six."

The album also features collaborations with Ameri-

WATCHLIST

Still *Rocking*



INDUS CREED

Founded in 1984, this band released two hard-rock albums as *Rock Machine* before adding Indian instrumentation and rebranding in 1993. Their eponymous 1995 album achieved major success before they disbanded in 1997, but a new lineup—founding members joined by new blood—has been touring and playing new music since 2010.

SOULMATE



Formed in 2003, the Shillong-based blues rock band, fronted by songwriting duo Tipriti Kharbangar and Rudy Wallang, has been a critical darling for over two decades. Their last album *Give Love* came out in 2020, and the band played it on their nationwide tour last summer.



MOTHERJANE

Kochi's Motherjane are one of the most influential bands in India, thanks to their early amalgamation of progressive rock and Carnatic music. They've got two studio